against eleven, England would have won. The papers and everybody else, of course, turned that into him saying it was my fault England had lost to Argentina.

The players came back into the dressing room and it was deathly quiet. Alan Shearer sat down next to me. ‘Sorry Al,’ was all I could think of to say. Alan just stared at the floor in front of him. What could anybody say? Only each individual player knows what was in his mind after that game. I won’t ever forget that Tony Adams was the one man who came and found me. The first time I’d been in an England squad with him, Tony had scared me to death. Away to Georgia in a qualifier, just a couple of minutes before we went out for the game, he’d stood up in the dressing room. ‘Right, lads! This is ours. We deserve this. We’ve come out here to win it!’ It wasn’t just that Tony was loud, it was the passion and the determination in his voice. I couldn’t believe the ferocity of it. It was one of those moments when you’re shocked into a new level of commitment. Not that you didn’t care before: but being in that dressing room, witnessing how much it mattered to Tony, was inspiring to someone who was just starting out as an international player. England losing in Saint-Etienne hurt him as much as it hurt anybody, especially as he thought he might not play for his country again. It was awful in the dressing room that night. There could be no disappointment like it. But Tony came over and put a hand on my shoulder.

‘Whatever’s happened here, I think you’re a great young lad and an excellent young player. I’m proud to have played for England with you. You can be stronger for this. You can be a better player after it.’

We left the ground and my mum and dad were waiting by the coach. I fell into Dad’s arms and started sobbing. I couldn’t stop. I’m a bit embarrassed thinking about it now but, at the time, I just couldn’t help myself. Eventually, I calmed down and Dad pushed me onto the coach. I sat down and leaned my head against the cool of the window. Gary Neville got on and sat next to me. He could see I’d been crying. He could see I might be about to start again.

‘Don’t let anyone see you like this. You shouldn’t be like this. You haven’t done anything wrong. What’s happened has happened.’

I looked at him.

‘Victoria’s pregnant.’

Gary’s eyes opened that bit wider.